

# A VOYAGE IN MEMORY

A ship with an explosive human cargo sails through Amitav Ghosh's new novel, the first in an ambitious trilogy



**SEA OF POPPIES**  
by AMITAV GHOSH  
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■ By S. Prasannarajan

If migration is the movement that animates history to the rhythm of the outcast's heartbeats, Amitav Ghosh is its most elegant choreographer. It is as if the exodus that defies borders—both inherited and imposed—with the dreams and delirium of the refugee is an idea that Ghosh, the brainiest storyteller at work in Indian writing in English today, can't live without. And his passion is matched by the yearning of his characters for whom a life scarred by denial and dispossession is not something to be abandoned but to be reconstructed anew elsewhere, far beyond. In *The Circle of Reason*, his first novel, the picaresque of Alu the orphan takes him aboard a trawler that transports immigrants to Africa. In the genre-defying *In an Antique Land*, the novelist builds his own Alexandrian master work of civilisational crosscurrents with the dexterity of an anthropological detective and the imagination of a time-traveller. In *The Glass Palace*, stretching from the Mandalay of 1885 to the Myanmar of Aung San Suu Kyi's resistance in 1996, and which marks Ghosh's initiation into the grand narrative, Asia's biggest exodus is staged in the backdrop of war, exile and the loss of kingdom. In

his last novel, *The Hungry Tide*, even as we are being rowed into the riverbank mythologies of the Sunderbans, there is a parallel narrative that brings out the generational continuity of the tide country. It has been a journey of astonishing discoveries in which history takes over when memory fades.

We haven't come a long way, and it seems there is no pause in the voyage. There are only the possibilities of the unknown: "Slowly, as the vessel's motion made itself felt in the pit of every stomach, the noise yielded to a preg-

nant, fearful stillness. Now the migrants began to absorb the finality of what was under way: yes, they were moving, they were afloat, heading towards the void of the Black Water; neither death nor birth was as fearsome a passage as this, neither being experienced in full consciousness." Aboard the *Ibis*, the schooner that sails across *Sea of Poppies*, the first in a trilogy, is an awesome human cargo. The vessel first occurs as an epiphany to Deeti, the woman on whom Ghosh anchors his narrative that stretches from the poppy fields of Ghazipur to the Calcutta of East India Company to the Indian Ocean that sets the stage for the final act of liberation. The transformation of Deeti, a refugee from the funeral pyre of her husband—from a widow to a lover to the enigmatic leader of the rebellion—is as dramatic as the voyage itself.

Every passenger has a secret to preserve and a fantasy to pursue—like Deeti. They are an interesting lot: migrants, convicts, sailors, and others in search of freedom—or an identity. They are adventurers as well as dreamers, natives and foreigners. Zachary, the second mate with a hidden racial origin from Baltimore; Paulette, the French orphan with a captivating ancestral back story; Jodu, her long lost soul mate; Kalua, Deeti's lover and protector; Neel, the anglicised zamindar who has been wrongly banished by an English court; Baboo Nob Kissin, the bookkeeper on a ivine mission; Subedar



BRAINY STORY-TELLER: Ghosh

VIKRAM SHARMA